

Android going strong

700,000 Android phones are being activated on a daily basis

More adverts on FB

Facebook says everyone's Timelines will get one advert daily from Jan 2012

Tablet test

available in India, across all price ranges. To make it simpler for you, we've divided the tablets into two price segments — sub ₹20k and above ₹20k.

Sub-₹20k

This is the critical category — the one that helped the tablets become popular amongst the masses. This category has six tablets. Within this price band, two tablets are priced at less than ₹10,000 — the Mercury MTab and the Beetel Magiq (the first one, not to be confused with the Magiq II). Despite the two having a similar display size, they are vastly different from each other.

The MTab takes a lot of design cues from the Samsung Galaxy Tab P1000. The black and white plastic body has an okay build quality. The 4GB



Mercury MTab

HOW WE TESTED

For this tablet comparison, the test process included a combination of processes used in two separate categories — laptops and smartphones. This allowed us to compare and rate the tablets across all parameters: performance, features and the build.

You surely wouldn't want a tablet that is sluggish or hangs the moment you open a bunch of apps, would you? To ensure that we test the performance of all tablets, we ran a series of benchmarks. The benchmark tests: Quadrant, Antutu, LinPack (single thread + multi threads) and PeaceKeeper threw up scores that allowed us to objectively compare the performance of each machine.

The tablets are also a bit of gaming devices, to a certain extent. After all, you might suddenly want to play *Angry Birds* or the latest *Need For Speed* game. Hence, we ran the GLBenchmark 2.1 (Egypt standard + Pro Standard), which gives an idea of the graphics performance of the tablets.

All these benchmarks work on the Android platform, while Quadrant and Antutu aren't available on iOS. Incidentally, only PeaceKeeper is available for the BlackBerry Tablet OS!

Beyond the benchmarks, we also tested the startup time of each tablet. This was the time taken from the moment the power key is pressed, till the lock screen/home screen of the OS is displayed.

The tablet is also a multimedia device, and the audio/video performance needs to be analysed as well. We transferred a 720p HD video (.mkv) as well as a SD video (.avi) on to the tablets. By doing so, we not only get an idea of how good the display is and how smoothly the hardware can handle the video, but also which OS doesn't handle some basic video codecs. On such tablets, we installed a third-party media player with the necessary codec. The audio quality (clarity and loudness) was also analysed at this stage.

When you spend so much money for a tablet, you want it to look great too, right? We've given each one scores on the material used — plastic, aluminum or a mixture of the two. We have a band of two points within each, allowing us to differentiate between two tablets made of the same material, but that offer different quality.

What good is a tablet that doesn't have good battery life? There are two ways of testing this — one is the minimum battery backup offered, at full load. Playing a video in a loop till the battery runs down can test this. The other, and the more real-world scenario, is the method in which we use the tablet in consistent (re: daily) usage scenarios and see how good the battery is. This usage includes a bit of video viewing, web browsing, ebook reading, game playing with the Wi-Fi connected throughout.

internal memory is complemented by a microSD card, allowing up to 32 GB more. The Beetel Magiq, on the other hand, does things quite a bit differently. Firstly, it can actually work as a phone — it even has the call connect and disconnect buttons! The plastic body is topped off with an aluminum battery cover and an integrated kickstand. The kickstand feature will be quite useful for

video chats or watching videos. However, where the Magiq loses out to the MTab is in the feature set — resistive touchscreen and still stuck on older Android 2.2 when everyone else seems to have moved on to newer Android versions. Having said that, we should mention that the UI on the Magiq is indeed very good. It

follows the concept of multiple desktops, and allows you to categorise widgets, shortcuts and



Beetel Magiq



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Soups, Sauces & Miracle Masala
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